SAINT MICHAEL COLLEGE OF CARAGA

THE IMPACT OF SOCIAL MEDIA ON TOURIST' DESTINATION CHOICE

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The Faculty of
College of Tourism and Hospitality Management

In Partial Requirements for the Degree
BACHELOR OF SCIENCE IN TOURISM MANAGEMENT

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TABLE OF CONTENTS

			Pages
	TITLE PAGE		i
	CERTIFICATE OF PANEL APPROVAL		ii
	ABSTRACT		iii
	DEDICATION		iv
	ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS		v
	TABLE OF CONTENTS		vi
	LIST OF TABLES		viii
	LIST OF FIGURES		x
	CHAPTER		
	1	**THE PROBLEM AND ITS SCOPE**	1
		1.1 Background of the study	8
		1.2 Review of Related Literature	11
		1.3 Theoretical Framework	33
		1.4 Schematic Diagram	35
		1.5 Statement of the Problem/ Objectives of the Study	36
		1.6 Hypothesis	37
		1.7 Definition of Terms	38
	2	**RESEARCH METHODOLOGY**	9
		2.1 Research Design	40
		2.2 Research Locale	41
		2.3 Research Environment, Population and Sample	41
		2.4 Research Data and Analysis Plan	43
		2.5 Research Ethical Standards	45
		2.6 Data Gathering Procedure	49
	3	**RESULTS AND DISCUSSIONS**	19
		3.1 Presentation and Analysis of Data	51
		3.2 Proposed Intervention/ Output	51
	4	**SUMMARY, CONCLUSIONS AND RECOMMENDATIONS**	44
		4.1 Summary	52
		4.2 Conclusion	52

		4.3 Recommendations	52
REFERENCES			50
CURRICULUM VITAE			59
APPENDICES			
CERTIFICATE OF TECHNOLOGY BASED ASSESSMENT			68
PUBLISHABLE JOURNAL			100

SAINT MICHAEL COLLEGE OF CARAGA
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CERTIFICATE OF RESEARCH APPROVAL

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ABSTRACT

TITLE:	THE IMPACT OF SCOIAL MEDIA ON TOURIST' DESTINATION CHOICE
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LIST OF TABLES

Table	Pages
1	
2	
3	

CHAPTER 1

THE PROBLEM AND ITS SCOPE

1.1 Background of the study

Social media has changed how people find, plan, and pick places to travel. Facebook, Instagram, and TikTok are just a few of the platforms that now have a significant impact on travel experiences and ideas. Unlike traditional advertisements, social media leverages real people, authentic reviews, and influencers to share honest opinions and foster trust (Wibisono & Lale, 2024) This shift in tourism leads travelers to seek ideas and credibility from online communities rather than official sources. As digital interaction grows, so does social media's impact on tourism. Social media is changing the way places are marketed and how travelers get advice, build trust, and show who they are through travel. As social media's impact on travel choices and experiences grows, people in the tourism industry need to understand this shift.

Mohamad et al. (2022) found that positive travel experiences posted on social media greatly increase travelers' intentions to visit a destination, highlighting that social media word-of-mouth significantly influences travelers' preferences. Similarly, Saini et al. (2023) reported that travelers' destination choices are heavily influenced by the quality of social media content, its ability to capture attention, and the perceived trustworthiness of the source. Research consistently shows that the way tourism information appears on social media plays a central role in shaping travelers' destination choices. Wang & Yan (2022) found that travelers are much more likely to visit a destination after encountering high-quality tourism information online, with trust and self-congruity acting as key drivers of this effect. Expanding this perspective, Keelson et al. (2024) demonstrated that destination image, tourist satisfaction, behavioral intentions, and the availability of tourism information substantially influence destination selection through social media, even though social media itself does not exert a purely direct effect. The valence of shared

experiences also matters: Sinh & Thai (2024) reported that negative experiences posted online tend to discourage travel, whereas positive experiences and tourism advertising increase the likelihood of visiting a destination. Within this broader context, trust in social media influencers has been shown to shape the entire decision-making process from the initial desire to explore a new place to information search, comparison of alternatives, and final purchase (Pop et al., 2021a). However, influencer content operates alongside other forms of user-generated content: genuine reviews and real-life photos shared by ordinary travelers can sometimes have an even stronger impact on destination choice than influencers themselves (Barbu et al., 2024). The persuasive power of influencer content is particularly pronounced at the pre-purchase stage, when its informativeness and convincing appeal significantly guide travelers' evaluations of potential destinations (Pourazad et al., 2025). For younger cohorts such as Generation Z and Millennials, travel influencers become especially influential when their content is perceived as authentic, visually appealing, and reflective of local culture and sustainable practices (Băltescu & Untaru, 2025). Complementing these insights, Barman & Sharma (2021) highlight that social media participation, perceptions of destination uniqueness, and the complexity of trip planning further shape university students' tourism choices, illustrating how influencer-driven and other user-generated content interact with individual perceptions and destination attributes to influence where people ultimately decide to go.

Local studies in the Philippines support these global patterns but add particular insights to this study. According to Arreza (2021) Generations X and Y are mainly influenced by Facebook, while Gen Z and Millennials rely more on visually driven platforms such as Instagram and YouTube. Building on this shift toward highly visual and mobile-friendly media, Alejo et al. (2025 and Datu et al. (2025) found that TikTok now plays a significant role in shaping travel decisions among Gen Z and Millennials, with vlogs and short-form videos strongly influencing their destination choices.

In the Philippine context, Belza et al. (2024) further confirmed TikTok's effectiveness as a powerful tourism marketing tool, showing how destination-related content on the platform can attract and persuade potential travelers. Similarly, Dela Cerna et al. (2024) reported that Gen Z and Millennials in Cebu use social media not only to decide where to go but also to share their own travel experiences, indicating that digital influence extends before, during, and even after the trip. Beyond platform preference, Filipino studies also highlight practical decision-making factors such as accessibility, costs, and destination characteristics. Jorge-Acain (2022) observed that these details often encountered through influencers' follower counts and curated travel content serve as important guides in shaping travel choices. In rural areas, social media has also emerged as an effective channel for encouraging changes in travel plans and promoting lesser-known destinations (Abad & Borbon, 2021; Maybelle et al., 2023). For tourism professionals, understanding these evolving patterns is crucial, as social media not only influences travel choices but also intensifies competition among destinations and enables more personalized trip experiences (Tayco et al., 2024). This is especially relevant for today's younger generation, which is recognized for its preference for digital-first experiences, its emphasis on authenticity, and its desire for individuality (Merabet, 2020), As people increasingly integrate social media into their daily lives using it to share photos, videos, ideas, and events, it has also become a key source of information and a decision-making tool, helping users connect with others, build networks, join interest-based communities, and ultimately make more informed travel decisions.

Tourism has evolved into a highly competitive and dynamic industry, where travelers' decisions are no longer influenced solely by traditional advertising or word-of-mouth recommendations. With the rise of social media platforms such as TikTok, Facebook, YouTube, and many more, travelers now have immediate access to a wealth of visually compelling content, reviews, and recommendations that shape their perceptions of destinations. Social media has

become a virtual guidebook, inspiring wanderlust, shaping expectations, and building trust through peer reviews and influencer endorsements. Given the growing reliance on digital platforms, it is essential to examine how social media contributes to the decision-making process of tourists and how it influences their final destination choices. This study is important as it provides insights into the behaviors of different groups of travelers, such as Generation X, Y, and Z, who heavily depend on social media for travel inspiration. The findings are expected to benefit destination marketers, tourism boards, and travel agencies by offering practical recommendations for designing effective digital marketing strategies that align with the preferences and behaviors of modern tourists.

In BueNasCar, tourism is an essential part of the local economy, and social networks have become one of the main channels that influence decisions on which places to visit or avoid (Mohamad et al., 2022; Saini et al., 2023), The study provides valuable insights to restaurateurs, tour operators, the CTHM Department, and other tourism-related businesses in the area on how online platforms shape visitors' perceptions and motives. By understanding which types of social media content, such as influencer posts, traveler reviews, or shared photos capture the attention of potential tourists, these stakeholders can refine their marketing strategies, improve service offerings, and build stronger connections with their target audience (Pop et al., 2021). For travelers, particularly younger generations who are highly active on social media, the findings underscore the need to critically evaluate the content they encounter online; by distinguishing reliable user-generated content from biased promotions, they are better positioned to make travel choices that are genuine and fulfilling (Barman & Sharma, 2021). Finally, for local tourism authorities, the CTHM Department, and academic researchers, this study contributes to the growing body of work on digital travel campaigns at the domestic level, and its results may be used to develop promotional strategies that highlight BueNasCar's attractions while maintaining

authenticity and credibility in the online environment (Băltescu & Untaru, 2025; Barbu et al., 2024).

1.2 Review of Related Literature

Tourist destination choice is influenced by several interrelated factors that are strongly shaped by social media. Information shared by travelers such as photos, stories, and reviews help others form realistic expectations of what a place is like, while the destination image presented on social media through posts and videos makes a location appear attractive, interesting, or trendy. Behavioral intention is also visible online through likes, comments, shares, and follows, which signal people's interest in visiting a destination. Studies further show that social media marketing, including targeted advertisements and influencer promotions, increases destination visibility and encourages travelers to consider specific places (Halit Akın & Şener, 2024). In addition, tourism satisfaction expressed on social media influences future travelers: positive experiences inspire others to visit, whereas negative feedback can discourage potential visitors. Altogether, these factors demonstrate that social media significantly shapes how people become aware of, evaluate, and ultimately choose their travel destinations.

As a communication technology, social media creates constant interaction between information providers and users, leading people to spend increasing amounts of time on virtual platforms (ZORLU & CANDAN, 2023). Facebook, Instagram, TikTok, YouTube, Pinterest, and similar sites allow users to "see the world" through visually rich and engaging content that sparks curiosity and a desire to travel. Because these platforms are widely used especially among Generations X, Y, and Z they have become essential tools for searching for and sharing travel information, comparing options, and reviewing user-generated content. Previous research confirms that social media not only raises awareness of destinations but also directly influences

travel decisions and intensifies competition among tourism providers, making online presence a crucial concern for the industry (Ilieva, 2022; Nur'afifah & Prihantoro, 2021). Moreover, the travel preferences of Gen X, Y, and Z are uniquely shaped by the digital age and evolving socio-cultural dynamics, which further underscores the need to examine how social media influences their destination choices (Chian, 2023).

Tourist Destination Choice

In this study**,** tourist destination preference (tourist destination choice) will be the main dependent variable. It will describe how strongly tourists will tend to choose or favor a destination after being exposed to social media content such as photos, videos, reviews, and posts. This construct will be anchored on the work of Halit Akın & Şener (2024) who examined destination choice as the outcome of several social media elements, namely information shared by travelers, destination image on social media, behavioral intention on social media, the effects of social media on marketing, and tourism satisfaction on social media. Their findings show that all of these elements are related to destination preference, and that destination image, behavioral intention, and tourism satisfaction have a particularly strong effect on the preferences of Generation Z travelers (Halit Akın & Şener, 2024).

Tourism destination decision-making is shaped by a combination of service quality and social media influencesMandasari (2021) points out that the quality of services provided by tourism service suppliers plays a crucial role in whether tourists decide to visit or return to a destination. Complementing this, Al-Sheebani & Abdallah (2021) argues that social media is closely linked to the travel decision-making process and destination choice, as online content increasingly guides how tourists form impressions and make comparisons. In this study, tourist

destination choice is treated as the main dependent variable and refers to how strongly tourists tend to choose or favor a particular destination after being exposed to social media content such as photos, videos, reviews, and posts. This construct is anchored on the work of Akın and Şener (2024), who conceptualized destination preference as the outcome of several social media-related elements. In their model, information shared by travelers, destination image on social media, behavioral intention on social media, the effects of social media on marketing, and tourism satisfaction on social media all influence destination preference. Their findings show that these elements are significantly related to destination preference among Generation Z, with destination image, behavioral intention, and tourism satisfaction exerting especially strong effects on which destinations young people are inclined to visit (Akın & Şener, 2024).

In the Philippine context, empirical evidence shows similar patterns but within local digital and cultural realities. (Ann et al., 2021) examined "Social Media and its Influence to Tourist Decision Making and Preferences" and found that specific characteristics of tourism-related posts such as trustworthiness, usefulness, novelty, and enjoyment directly affect Filipino travelers' preferred destinations. Their results indicate that tourism posts which are perceived as reliable and enjoyable are more likely to convert into concrete destination preferences, especially among young, active social media users. Complementing this, Casquejo et al. (2024) preference analysis in Coron, Palawan, revealed that tourists' destination choices are shaped by a mix of natural attractions, perceived safety, and online visibility, suggesting that destinations with strong positive narratives and visibility in digital channels enjoy higher preference levels.

The present study will follow this idea but will apply it in the local setting of Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen (BueNasCar). Instead of treating the five elements only as independent variables, they will be used as sub-variables or dimensions of tourist destination preference. In

other words, tourist destination preference in this thesis will be described in terms of: (1) information shared by travelers, (2) destination image on social media, (3) behavioral intention on social media, (4) the effects of social media on marketing, and (5) tourism satisfaction on social media.

Information Shared by Travelers

Information shared by travelers**,** will refer to the influence of travel tips, reviews, and experiences posted by ordinary users on social media. Previous research shows that user-generated information is a major factor in how tourists form their decisions. For instance, Aboalganam et al. (2025) note that tourists now rely heavily on other travelers' posts to learn about problems, amenities, and quality at a destination, and that such information shapes destination image and visit intention (Aboalganam et al., 2025). Likewise, a study on social media tourism information quality finds that higher quality information on social media leads to stronger travel intention by influencing both rational evaluation and emotional responses (Li & Zhou, 2024).

Research on user-generated content (UGC) consistently shows that what travelers share online plays a central role in shaping others' destination choices. Nguyen & Tong (2023) found that travel-related UGC on social media significantly increases tourists' intention to choose a destination, with destination image and desire to visit acting as key mediators in this relationship. Similarly, Yang-Huang et al. (2022) reported that Chinese millennials rely heavily on user-generated travel posts on multifunctional social media apps because they perceive real experiences and advice from other travelers as more authentic and trustworthy than official marketing messages. Extending this idea, Rajeev Sharma (2022) showed that travelers increasingly prefer user-created travel blogs and vlogs over company-generated content when deciding where

to go, reinforcing the role of UGC as a primary information source in the decision-making process. Li & Zhou (2024) further emphasized that the quality of tourism information on social media particularly its accuracy, completeness, and usefulness positively influences travel intention, suggesting that detailed and credible information from other travelers becomes a decisive factor in destination selection. A review article on "The Impact of Social Media on Tourist Destination Choices" also underscores that reviews, tips, and stories shared by friends and other users on platforms such as Facebook, Instagram, and YouTube create social proof and trust, which in turn strengthen tourists' confidence in their destination choices. Taken together, these studies clearly support the idea that traveler-shared content is not just supplementary, but a crucial determinant in the selection of tourist destinations.

A more recent paper on The Impact of Social Media on Tourist Destination Choices points out that many travelers use social media to read reviews, comments, and practical tips from other tourists before deciding where to go, and that this form of electronic word of mouth (eWOM) reinforces trust and confidence in the chosen destination (Wibisono & Lale, 2024)**.** In the Philippine context, (Ann et al., 2021b) reports that the details and content of tourism-related social media posts such as personal experiences and recommendations—have a significant influence on tourists' preferences and planned destinations (Ann et al., 2021).

Based on these studies, information shared by travelers will be treated as one component of tourist destination preference in this thesis. Respondents who will strongly agree that other travelers' posts guide their destination choices will be described as having a higher level of this sub-dimension.

Destination Image on Social Media

A substantial body of research will substantiate the notion that destination image cultivated via social media exerts a direct influence on destination selection. (Pan et al., 2021)) demonstrate that destination image, as shaped by social network members' posts, profoundly impacts tourists' destination selection, with variations observed among different sociodemographic groups. Vu et al. (2025) discover that marketing efforts on social media affect both the cognitive and emotional aspects of a destination's image, which in turn makes people more likely to want to visit cultural destinations. (Androniki Kavoura Teresa Borges-Tiago Flavio Tiago, 2024) contend that travelers' engagement with social media content significantly influences overall image formation via cognitive and affective destination images; a more positive image results in heightened behavioral intentions towards the destination. (Afshardoost & Eshaghi, 2020) recently found that destination image has a big positive effect on tourist satisfaction, the desire to return, and word-of-mouth in a social media setting. This connects image to behaviors related to choice. This research substantiates the utilization of destination image on social media as a sub-dimension that will affect tourists' preferences for particular destinations.

Destination image on social media**,** will refer to how tourists' mental pictures and perceptions of destinations are shaped by social media content. Destination image has long been recognized as a key predictor of destination preference and travel intention. Halit Akın & Şener (2024) found that destination image on social media has a significant impact on the destination preferences of Generation Z, meaning that young tourists tend to prefer destinations that have a strong and positive image online (Halit Akın & Şener, 2024).

Recent reviews also emphasize this link. Alghamdi & Abdulwahid (2025) conclude that social media marketing activities play a critical role in forming perceived destination image, trust,

and visit intentions, especially in emerging destinations (Alghamdi & Abdulwahid, 2025). Similarly, a study on the "driving forces of social media" reports that destination image, tourists' goals, and available social media information together have a strong influence on destination decisions (Correia et al., 2025).

Through social media, tourists are now able to share their thoughts and opinions with greater impact and efficiency (Akhtar et al., 2023). To document their interactions and experiences with local people and destinations, many travelers regularly use digital devices to upload photos, travel stories, and reviews on platforms such as Facebook, Instagram, and Twitter. Because online reviews are usually concise, they clearly reflect the main points that users want to emphasize. At the same time, tourism is among the industry's most profoundly transformed both positively and negatively by the growing use and development of digital technologies (Safaa et al., 2021)

When tourists repeatedly see attractive visual and textual content about a place, they build a more favorable image of that destination. This improved image then leads to higher preference and intention to visit. For this reason, destination image on social media will be considered a core dimension of tourist destination choice in the present study.

Behavioral Intention on Social Media

Research on travel intention will demonstrate that behavioral intentions influenced by social media are intricately connected to destination selection and preferences. Susanto et al. (2024) study on Influencing Travel Decisions demonstrates that social media engagement metrics (likes, comments, shares) and endorsements from influencers modify tourists' perceptions of prospective destinations and markedly elevate their travel aspirations, thus aiding in destination selection. (Wei et al.2025) investigate the impact of social media characteristics, including source

credibility, content quality, and destination image, on impulsive travel intentions, ultimately concluding that these intentions significantly affect actual travel behavior. Han & Chen (2022) and (Yılmazdoğan et al., 2021) examine Millennials, demonstrating that the credibility of social media influencers and the attitudes they endorse significantly impact users' travel intentions. This means that social media can be a good way to find out what people want to do. These findings corroborate that behavioral intention on social media is a crucial element connecting social media exposure to tourists' genuine preferences. Similarly, Rasoolimanesh et al. (2021) examined behavioral intentions on tourism experiences in a heritage tourism context. The study collected data from domestic cultural tourists in Kashan, Iran, and concluded that domestic culture and tourists' site knowledge positively influences tourists' behavioral intentions toward a tourist destination.

In their study, Halit Akın & Şener (2024) show that behavioral intention on social media is one of the elements most strongly associated with destination preference, indicating that when Gen Z users intend to visit or engage with a destination after seeing social media content, they are more likely to actually prefer that destination (Halit Akın & Şener, 2024).

Other scholars also highlight the relationship between social media, behavioral intention, and decisions. For example, a study on social media and tourism decisions finds that behavioral intentions, such as the intention to visit or recommend a destination, have a significant effect on actual destination choice and that social media directly shapes these intentions (Susanto et al., 2024). In addition, research on user-generated content among Generation X,Y and Z shows that UGC influences trust, destination image, and visit intention, with destination image and trust mediating the effect of UGC on behavioral intentions (Nguyen & Tong, 2023).

In this thesis, behavioral intention on social media will therefore be regarded as another dimension of tourist destination preference. Respondents who indicate that social media content makes them intend to visit or recommend a destination will be considered to have stronger preference for that destination.

The Effects of Social Media on Marketing

A number of authors directly associate social media marketing efforts with destination image, travel intention, and consequently, destination preference. Alghamdi & Abdulwahid (2025) conducted a systematic review and determined that social media marketing activities enhance the perceived image of a destination, foster trust, and increase tourists' intentions to visit, particularly in emerging destinations. (Ismail et al., 2025) put forth a conceptual framework positing that interaction, trendiness, and electronic word-of-mouth, as elements of social media marketing activities, positively affect destination image and travelers' behavioral intentions. Alzaydi & Elsharnouby (2023) conducted empirical research demonstrating that social media marketing initiatives and electronic reputation substantially influence the intention to visit a heritage destination by affecting its image. Armutcu et al. (2023) illustrate that digital marketing and social media significantly influence tourists' behavioral intentions regarding destination selection, highlighting the impact of online marketing content on shaping preferences. All of these studies back up your idea to make the effects of social media on marketing a sub-variable that will affect where people want to go on vacation.

Social media has become a key tool for tourism marketing, allowing destinations and businesses to reach large audiences at low cost. Halit Akın & Şener (2024) treat the effects of social media on marketing as one of the social media elements related to destination preference, noting that social media has changed both tourist behavior and marketing strategies.

A broader review by Dolnicar and colleagues (2023) argues that digital marketing and social media campaigns strongly affect tourist behavior and intentions, and that destinations must create authentic and informative content to attract visitors effectively **(**Armutcu et al., 2023). Another systematic review on social media marketing finds that social media marketing activities (such as interactive content, promotions, and storytelling) shape perceived destination image, trust, and travelers' intentions to visit, especially in emerging destinations (Alghamdi & Abdulwahid, 2025).

Because marketing messages and campaigns are embedded in most social media platforms that tourists use, it is reasonable to expect that stronger exposure to effective social media marketing will be associated with stronger destination preference. This study will therefore include the effects of social media on marketing as a sub-variable of tourist destination preference.

Tourism Satisfaction on Social Media

According to Halit Akın & Şener (2024) identify tourism satisfaction on social media as another element that significantly affects destination preference for Generation Z. Their results suggest that when tourists are satisfied with their experiences and see positive satisfaction expressed on social media, they are more likely to prefer those destinations in the future (Halit Akın & Şener, 2024)

In research, this will demonstrate that tourism satisfaction particularly when disseminated or amplified on social media exerts a significant influence on intentions to revisit and future destination selections. Wilopo and Nuralam (2024) discover that social media marketing activities (interaction, trendiness, e-WOM) elevate tourist satisfaction, subsequently

significantly boosting the intention to revisit among international tourists; this indicates that contented tourists are more inclined to select the same or analogous destinations again. The studies by Mikulić et al. (2021) argued that tourist satisfaction and tourist delight lead to sustainable performance. The study added that food and beverages have a positive effect on tourist satisfaction. An et al. (2022) argued that tourist satisfaction and tourist delight lead to sustainable performance. Similarly, Elgarhy (2023) added that tourist satisfaction is crucial in achieving long-term performance. The study further revealed that tourist satisfaction revisits intention and income generation for the tourist service provider. Vu et al. (2025) conducted a study on memorable tourism experiences, revealing that destination attachment and the sharing of travel experiences on social media serve as mediators in the relationship between memorable experiences and the intention to revisit.

This suggests that online expressions of satisfaction enhance future preferences for the destination. By adding social media variables to the Theory of Planned Behavior, Susanto et al. (2024) show that tourist satisfaction, along with social media information and perceived service quality, is a strong predictor of the intention to return to a tourist attraction. Other studies also show that satisfaction, especially when shared online, is linked to stronger intentions and positive decisions. For instance, a study in Ghana reports that social media usage, behavioral goals, destination image, and tourists' level of contentment jointly influence destination decisions (Keelson et al., 2024) Research on user-generated content further indicates that satisfied tourists who post positive content contribute to destination awareness and perceived quality, which in turn increase the intention to visit (Santos et al., 2023).

Age

Age is a core socio-demographic factor that shapes how tourists use social media and how strongly online content influences their destination decisions. Generational studies show that

younger cohorts particularly Millennials and Generation Z are “digital natives” who rely heavily on social networking sites, image- and video-based platforms when planning trips, whereas older tourists tend to combine social media with more traditional information sources. In a study of tourists in Cape Verde, Martins et al. (2025) report that younger visitors are more likely to consult Instagram and TikTok for inspiration and reviews, while older age groups still favor Facebook and more conventional channels, but nonetheless acknowledge social media as a relevant information source in their destination choices.

Building on this, research that explicitly adopts a generational lens shows that age conditions how user-generated content (UGC) affects destination image and intention to visit. Correia et al. (2025) find that UGC on social media has a stronger impact on perceived destination image among younger generations than among older cohorts, suggesting that age moderates the relationship between online content and travel intentions. ikTok-focused studies apply similar reasoning: Zhou et al. (2023) demonstrate that short video content on TikTok significantly influences the destination choices of young Chinese tourists, and that age (millennials vs. Gen Z) moderates the strength of TikTok’s effect on destination selection. Likewise, Pitanatri et al. (2024) show that Gen Z travelers treat social media as both an information source and a space for self-expression, making them especially responsive to visually appealing and interactive travel posts.

Beyond platform-specific work, broader reviews on tourism in the digital age conclude that younger tourists are generally more engaged with social media throughout the travel decision process from initial inspiration to post-trip sharing while older age groups display more selective, utilitarian use of online platforms (e.g., to verify information or check reviews). These patterns are consistent with Philippine empirical evidence: Jorge-Acain’s (2022) study on social media and travelers’ choice of tourist destination notes that respondents are predominantly millennials

whose social media use is significantly associated with their age, influencing how frequently they consult social media about travel and which platforms they prefer.

In the present study, age is therefore treated as a key profile variable alongside sex, civil status, education, and social media usage characteristics, since different age groups (particularly Gen Z and young adults vs. older travelers) are likely to differ in how they interpret, trust, and act on social-media travel content when choosing destinations in BueNasCar. Examining age allows the researchers to determine whether social-media-driven influences on destination choice are stronger among younger tourists, or whether older cohorts are increasingly adopting similar online decision-making patterns.

Sex

Sex plays a moderating role in the relationship between social media use and destination choice. Research consistently shows that gender differences influence how individuals use and are affected by social media in travel planning. Travel often serves as a means of self-representation on social media. Since women tend to be more expressive when creating their online identities, they may be more affected by aspirational travel content and lifestyle branding (Yang-Huang et al., 2022). Recent studies show that social media affects people differently depending on their gender. Men and women interact with online content differently, process travel information in unique ways, and have different destination preferences (Han & Chen, 2022).

(Anton Joseph et al., 2024) contend that gender substantially influences the effect of social media content on travel choices. Their research on Vietnamese millennials indicated that female tourists were more swayed by the emotional and visual content of travel influencers, whereas male tourists preferred informational and activity-oriented posts. (Krátki et al., 2022) mentioned that women are more active consumers of content on social media sites, and they

tend to organize their travels online more frequently, than their male counterparts. Women were more likely to pay attention to influencers, other people, and online reviews when they were trying to decide where to go. The study found that when women talk about travel, they often care more about how things look and how other people see them. This has a big effect on where they choose to go. Women were more likely to listen to what influencers, other users, and online reviews said when they were trying to choose a place to go. The study emphasized that women tend to value aesthetic presentation and social validation in travel-related posts, which strongly affect their destination choices.

Vivien et al. (2022) also examined how sex influences the impact of social media on travel decision-making among young adults in the Philippines. The findings indicated that female participants engaged more with travel vloggers and Instagram travel pages, whereas male participants relied more on YouTube and Facebook groups for practical information. The researchers emphasized that these disparities arise from divergent motivations females pursue emotional connection and aesthetic appeal, whereas males prioritize adventure, cost-effectiveness, and convenience.

The United Nations World Tourism Organization (UNWTO) says that sex-based differences still affect how people travel around the world. Women are becoming increasingly critical decision-makers in the tourism market. They often plan and organize trips based on what they see on social media and what influencers post. The report said that more women are joining online travel communities, making digital engagement even more critical in deciding where to go.

The Study by Oblanca et al. (2022) also found that sex affects how tourists understand and trust online content. Women tourists said they felt more emotionally connected to and trusted influencer recommendations, while men tourists tended to trust information that was based on facts, reviews, and what their friends said. The research concluded that acknowledging

these gender-specific trends can help tourism marketers customize content strategies to effectively engage both demographics.

For example, women are more likely to respond to influencer posts that use emotional and visual storytelling because they value authenticity, looking good, and trustworthiness. On the other hand, men often prefer content that is informational or experiential and shows adventure, status, or expertise. Gender-segmented strategies are becoming more common in the tourism marketing industry. Influencer partnerships and content tone are tailored to the behavior of the target audience (Hussain et al., 2024).

Civil Status

Civil status (or marital status) is a significant demographic variable that determines the differing behaviors of tourists during travel and their use of social media. It shows how people live, how their families are set up, and what they have to do socially. These things often affect their choices and motivations when choosing where to go. For instance, married couples usually pick places to visit that are good for families and don't cost too much. Also, single travelers may be more likely to make spontaneous travel plans based on online content created by their peers.

According to (Kamarulzaman et al., 2025) in their study "Overtourism and Social Media: The Impact of Social Media Attachment on Tourists' Decision-Making Behavior," approximately 50.8% of respondents were married, with the authors noting that demographic composition, including marital status, helped contextualize how tourists use platforms differently. Married participants were more likely to follow recommendation-based attachments on Facebook and YouTube, while single respondents leaned toward opinion-driven exploration on Instagram and Twitter. These distinctions highlight that civil status influences how emotional and informational attachments to social media content shape tourist flows and destination choices.

Similarly, (Jorge-Acain, 2022) in "Power of Social Media Usage Over Travelers' Choice of Tourist Destination" found that while marital status was a considered demographic factor, it exhibited minimal direct influence on destination decision-making. However, it still helped interpret differences in engagement patterns. Single travelers tended to respond more positively to influencer-driven, visually engaging campaigns, whereas married individuals were more likely to engage with informative or review-oriented content.

Additionally, the conference paper "Social Media and Travel Planning Behavior: Influencing Content on Facebook, Instagram, and YouTube" (2024) highlighted that marital status played a significant role in how travelers approached their trip planning. Married respondents demonstrated more family-oriented travel motives and tended to rely on Facebook and YouTube for trustworthy reviews and destination insights. In contrast, single respondents used Instagram to explore aspirational destinations and visual inspirations. The authors recommended that Destination Marketing Organizations (DMOs) segment campaigns by marital or household status to improve targeting efficiency.

Employment Status

Employment status also plays a vital role in how travelers engage with social media when planning their trips. According to (Jorge-Acain, 2022), 66.2% of respondents were employed, indicating that those with stable occupations are more likely to use social media actively for travel planning and are financially able to turn digital inspiration into real travel experiences. The study also found a significant association between occupation and social media use, particularly in device preference and time spent online. Employed travelers are more inclined to use mobile devices for quick travel research and social networking, often prioritizing destinations that fit their work schedules and budgets.

Research also indicates that employment provides the economic capacity to actualize travel plans influenced by online content. Etrata et al. (2025) highlighted that employed individuals are more responsive to online promotions and influencer recommendations because they possess the means to convert online exposure into tangible actions such as bookings and visits. On the other hand, students or unemployed users engage more in aspirational travel behaviors, following social media pages and influencers to dream of or plan future trips rather than immediate ones (Ghosh & Mukherjee, 2022).

Educational Attainment

Educational attainment significantly influences how individuals use social media in making travel-related decisions. According to (Chowdhury, 2025), Researchers in the field of education have identified numerous methods to leverage social media to improve the learning experience. Jorge-Acain (2022) found that most travelers were college graduates (69.3%), indicating that individuals with higher education levels tend to have greater exposure to social media platforms and stronger digital literacy. Educated travelers are better able to critically evaluate travel content, compare destinations, and assess the credibility of online information before making decisions. It aligns with (Wang & Yan, 2022) who emphasized that Generation Z university students display higher discernment in processing travel information on digital platforms, particularly through structured reviews and destination visuals.

Education also affects travelers' ability to distinguish between genuine and exaggerated travel content. According to (Sultan et al., 2020), higher educational attainment fosters analytical thinking, making individuals less susceptible to misleading promotional materials and more reliant on factual or experience-based posts. In contrast, those with lower levels of education may rely more on social influence and peer recommendations. Jorge-Acain (2022) further explained that

college-educated respondents use social media not only for leisure inspiration but also as a practical source for comparing travel costs, accessibility, and amenities.

Average Monthly Income

Tourism demand research consistently shows that higher household income is positively associated with higher tourism expenditure and more frequent or longer trips. Using Chinese household data, Ma et al. 2024) find that tourism expenditure is income-inelastic but strongly positive: a 1% increase in per capita household income raises per capita tourism expenditure by approximately 0.51–0.64%, with stronger effects among households at higher expenditure quantiles and in more affluent regions. Similarly, (Mihai et al., 2023)) report that families and older tourists with higher incomes are positively associated with longer length of stay, underscoring how economic resources shape the intensity of tourism consumption.

Income does not only influence *how much* tourists travel; it also interacts with motives and destination types. Using threshold regression, a South African study shows that different income bands are associated with different travel motives and preferred destination types (e.g., beach tourism, visiting friends and relatives, religious sites, museums, and nature reserves), with clear breakpoints where motives shift as income increases (Struwig & du Preez, 2024).This suggests that income segments can be targeted with distinct marketing messages and products, and that social-media campaigns may resonate differently depending on tourists' budget constraints and willingness to pay for particular destination attributes. Reviews of micro-economic determinants of tourist expenditure reach similar conclusions: income remains a central explanatory variable in models of individual tourism spending and destination choice.

Mihai et al. (2023) also highlight “economic power” and monthly income as fundamental variables influencing tourism demand and destination choice, reinforcing the idea that financial capacity underpins many of the decisions tourists make, even when those decisions are initiated by social-media exposure.

In a Philippine context, Jorge-Acain (2022) provides direct evidence that monthly income is significantly associated with social media usage related to travel: the study finds a statistically significant relationship between respondents’ monthly income and their social-media usage profile and concludes that socio-demographic characteristics including income must be considered when designing tourism marketing strategies on social networks. These findings imply that while travelers across income brackets may be equally exposed to travel content on platforms like Facebook, Instagram, and TikTok, higher-income groups are more capable of acting on that content by booking trips, staying longer, or choosing more expensive destinations and activities.

In the present study on BueNasCar, average monthly income is therefore included as a profile variable to capture how economic capacity interacts with social-media-influenced motivations. By comparing destination choices and levels of social-media influence across income brackets, the study can assess whether (1) lower-income tourists are more price-sensitive and thus more responsive to social-media posts emphasizing affordability and promotions, and (2) higher-income tourists are more likely to be swayed by aspirational, experience-focused content when deciding to visit BueNasCar.

Type of Social Network Used

Scholars consistently show that the type of social networking service most used by tourists is a key factor in how they gather travel information and choose destinations. In the Philippine

context, Arreza (2021) reported that Generations X and Y mainly rely on Facebook for travel-related information, whereas Generation Z and Millennials are more influenced by visually oriented platforms such as Instagram and YouTube, indicating that platform preference is strongly tied to age cohort. Similar generational patterns appear in international research: a study on tourists in Cape Verde found that older visitors preferred Facebook, while younger travellers favored Instagram and TikTok for planning and inspiration, demonstrating that different platforms dominate in different age groups and thus expose users to different kinds of travel content (Martins et al., 2025)Industry surveys reinforce these academic findings. Nico Chan (2024) stated that TikTok has nearly caught up with Facebook and Instagram. It has already exceeded X (formerly Twitter) as the most popular social media network among Filipinos aged 16 to 64, with 67.9%, despite its recent launch as an application. Furthermore, TikTok ads reach 65.3 % Filipino female users compared to 34.7% Filipino male users. On the other hand, Facebook is a critical player in this ecosystem, providing a platform for interaction, fun, news, open discussion, and even commerce. Aligning with this, Daniellette Tan et al. (2021) observed that Facebook primarily fosters community engagement, while Instagram drives aspirational travel through its imagery, confirming that platform-specific features and peer endorsements together enhance awareness, interest, and ultimately destination preference. (Phocuswright, 2024) and Jorge-Acain (2022)both report that Facebook, Instagram, YouTube, and the rapidly growing TikTok are now the leading platforms used for trip inspiration and that a large share of travellers has made specific travel decisions after viewing content on these services. Rajeev Sharma (2022) further explains that social media platforms are not just sources of basic information but active spaces where travellers compare options, read experiences, and form preferences.

While (Ann et al., 2021) show that the characteristics of posts encountered on these platforms, such as informativeness, reliability, and visual appeal significantly influence tourist

decision-making and preferences. Taken together, these studies show that tourists' "most used social networking service" effectively represents the digital environment in which they most often encounter travel content; therefore, including this variable in the respondents' profile is crucial for understanding how different platforms may shape awareness, evaluation, and ultimately tourist destination preference in the present study. Tourists' destination choices are closely tied to their social media habits, including the platforms they use, how they share content, and the degree to which they interact with others online. Visually driven sites such as Instagram, TikTok, and YouTube allow users to tell stories through photos and videos, which in turn shape emotions, expectations, and planned behaviors before, during, and after a trip (Tešin et al., 2022). Information-rich platforms like Facebook also play a key role by enabling users to read reviews, join discussions, and access detailed recommendations; in fact, Facebook has been identified as one of the most effective platforms for searching for and promoting tourist destinations .Focusing on Generation Z, Halit Akın & Şener (2024) found that Instagram and YouTube have a particularly strong influence on travel decisions, as their visual and interactive content significantly affects how young tourists perceive destinations and form intentions to visit, while Facebook and Twitter (X) exert comparatively weaker influence on this cohort. Complementing these findings, Mqwebu (2024) study in South Africa showed that influencer activity on Instagram, YouTube, and TikTok especially through photos, reels, and vlogs creates emotional resonance that translates into stronger visit intentions and higher travel spending.

Time Spent on Social Media

Time spent on social media is the total time people spend viewing, posting, or interacting with content on sites like Facebook, Instagram, TikTok, YouTube, and X (formerly Twitter). This variable shows how engaged users are and how much they have been exposed to digital marketing, influencer content, and destination promotions, which can change how they think and

make decisions. ed content, thereby influencing their travel intentions and destination preferences. Using social media is a time-consuming activity of children and adolescents. Health authorities have warned that excessive use of social media can negatively affect adolescent social, physical, and psychological health (You et al., 2022). Their research on Generation X, Y, and Z travelers in the Philippines found that individuals who spend over 3 hours per day on social media are more likely to encounter tourism advertisements, influencer content, and user-generated content that motivate them to explore new destinations. The researchers stressed that spending more time online makes people more familiar with and curious about a destination, thereby increasing their interest in traveling there. In a similar vein, a study by (Grover et al., 2022), on the effect of social media on tourists' decision-making found that the amount of time spent online is strongly associated with how much they know about a destination and how attractive they perceive it to be. The research indicated that individuals who regularly peruse travel websites and watch travel vlogs are more likely to form deep emotional connections with the destinations presented online. This constant exposure to positive travel content makes people want to visit the places featured.

Febyola et al. (2022) also noted that spending too much time on social media makes electronic word of mouth (eWOM) and online reviews even more powerful. Their research indicated that individuals who engage online for extended periods are more susceptible to peer recommendations, travel influencers, and brand ambassadors who endorse destinations or tourism services. The results indicated that the length of social media usage influences both information exposure and the degree of persuasion regarding travel-related choices. It measures how long users engage with these platforms, not how often they use them, why they use them, or the effects of their usage. Time spent on social media is usually given in minutes or hours per day.

Frequency of Social Media Use

This concept outlines the frequency with which individuals use social media platforms such as YouTube, Facebook, Instagram, and TikTok. It assesses how often users interact with these sites (daily, weekly, or occasionally) and focuses on user actions rather than the reasons behind or effects of their use. Social media is a big part of people's everyday life these days, especially for the younger generation. Social media has had a big impact on almost every major industry in the globe, but the travel and hospitality sectors have profited from it more than any other. Many people use social media platforms to find holiday destinations, where they can read positive evaluations from past travellers. The most trustworthy kind of advertising is earned media, like referrals from friends and family (Alyssa Angeles & Belandres, 2025). This idea discusses how often people use social media platforms such as YouTube, Facebook, Instagram, and TikTok. It studies how often people use these sites (daily, weekly, or occasionally) and what they do there, not why. (Wibisono & Lale, 2024) assessed both the frequency and duration of travel-related social media use among respondents, indicating that individuals who engaged more frequently and extensively with social platforms were more inclined to rely on social media content when choosing tourist destinations. Tracking frequency helps researchers understand how seeing duplicate content on a platform repeatedly makes a destination more visible and affects travelers' choices.

1.3 Theoretical Framework

The Uses and Gratifications Theory (Katz, Blumler, & Gurevitch, 1974) and the Stimulus–Organism–Response (SOR) Theory (Mehrabian & Russell, 1974) are the two main ideas behind this study. The Uses and Gratifications Theory says that people choose media platforms on purpose to meet certain needs, like getting information, having fun, connecting with others, and getting help with making decisions. This theory helps explain why tourists use social media to get reliable information, compare destinations, and make decisions based on content created by other users.

Social media makes it easy to find reviews, photos, and shared experiences, which helps users get the travel information they need that is both credible and visually appealing. So, things like travelers sharing information, creating an image of a destination, and planning a trip all fit with this theory because they show how people use media in a purposeful and need-driven way that helps them plan their trips and evaluate destinations.

The Stimulus–Organism–Response (SOR) Theory backs up the study even more. This theory says that things outside of us affect our mental states and, in the end, our behavior. When it comes to tourism, social media content like posts, reviews, ads, and promotional materials act as stimuli that affect how a traveler thinks and feels, which leads to perceptions like destination image and expected satisfaction. These internal evaluations help travelers make decisions about where to go by helping them process information and form preferences. These two theories work well together to help us understand how different parts of social media work together to affect how tourists make decisions. They show how important online information and images are in shaping how people think about destinations and what they choose to do.

1.4 Schematic Diagram

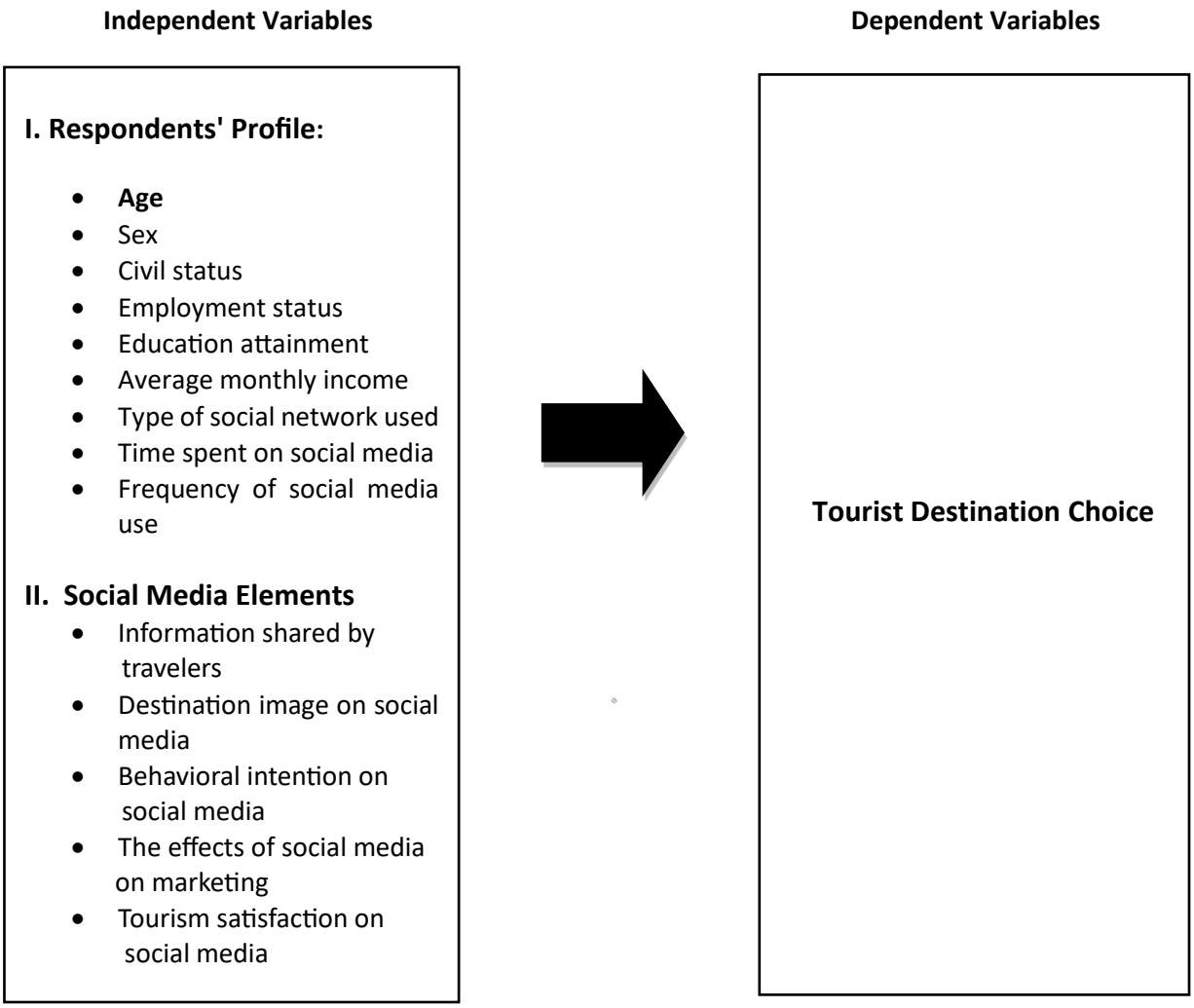


Figure 1. The Schematic Diagram shows the relationship between the dependent and independent variables.

1.5 Statement of the Problem

This study will the impact of social media and respondents' profiles on tourists' destination selection in the municipalities of Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen (BueNasCar). It will focus on how different characteristics of the respondents and selected social media factors will be related to their tourist destination choice.

Specifically, this study will seek to answer the following questions:

1. What is the profile of the respondents in terms of:
    - 1.1 Age;
    - 1.2 Sex;
    - 1.3 Civil status;
    - 1.4 Employment status;
    - 1.5 Educational attainment;
    - 1.6 Average monthly income
    - 1.7 Type of social network used;
    - 1.8 Time spent on social media; and
    - 1.9 Frequency of social media use?
2. To what extent is the tourist destination choice of the respondents based on the social media elements as to:
    - 2.1 Information shared by travelers;
    - 2.2 Destination image on social media;
    - 2.3 Behavioral intention on social media;
    - 2.4 The effects of social media on marketing; and
    - 2.5 Tourism satisfaction on social media?

3. Is there a significant difference between the respondents' profiles and their tourist destination choice when grouped according to their profile?
4. Is there a significant relationship between the respondents' profiles and their tourist destination choice when grouped according to their profile?

Hypothesis

Ho_1: There is no significant difference between the respondents' profiles and their tourist destination choice when grouped according to their profile?

Ho_2: There is no significant relationship between the respondents' profiles and their tourist destination choice when grouped according to their profile?

1.7 Scope and Limitations of the Study

The scope of this study will be limited to residents and tourists in the municipalities of Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen (BueNasCar), focusing specifically on their social media use and tourist destination choice. Because the participants will come only from this area, the findings may not be fully generalizable to other regions or countries with different social, cultural, or technological contexts. In addition, the study may be affected by response bias, since all data will be self-reported and will depend on the participants' individual perceptions, recall, and willingness to answer honestly.

1.8 Definition of Terms

To better understand and categorize the variables used in this study, the following terms are defined conceptually and as they will be used operationally in the research:

Behavioral Intention on social media. A tourists planned or intended behavior such as visiting, booking, recommending, or revisiting a destination formed after encountering content on social media. This will be measured using items adapted from Akın & Şener, such as "Information shared on social media has a strong influence on my decision-making intentions" and "I have a positive opinion towards tourism businesses advertised by social media influencers." Higher average scores mean stronger behavior intention influenced by social media.

Civil status. Refers to the respondent's marital condition, such as single, married, separated, or widowed. In this study, civil status will be treated as a categorical profile variable and will be determined based on the option selected by the respondent in the survey.

Destination Image on social media. The mental picture, impressions, and associations that a tourist develops about a destination based on images, videos, and descriptions encountered on social media. Destination image will be assessed with items like "Destination image has a strong influence on a person's choice of destination," "Images of destinations shared on social media influence me to go there," and "Videos shared on social media influence me to choose a destination." The mean of these items will represent how strongly social-media-based images shape the respondent's view of a destination.

Digital marketing. Refers to the use of social media platforms and other online tools by tourism organizations, businesses, and local government units (LGUs) to promote destinations and attract tourists. In this study, digital marketing will be reflected in items under "the effects of social media on marketing," where respondents will rate how such online promotions influence their destination decisions.

Educational attainment. Means the highest level of formal education completed by the respondent (e.g., senior high school, college level, college graduate). In this study, it will be measured as an ordinal profile variable based on the category checked in the questionnaire.

Employment status. Refers to the respondent's work situation (e.g., employed, self-employed, unemployed, student), which may influence income level and available travel time. In this study, employment status will be recorded through preset options and used as a demographic variable in the analysis.

Frequency of social media use. Indicates how often respondents access or engage with social media (for example, several times a day, once a day, a few times a week, or rarely). In this study, it will be measured using these ordered categories and analyzed as an ordinal profile variable.

Information Shared by travelers. User-generated information such as reviews, comments, tips, and personal stories posted by other travelers on social media, which guides others in choosing destinations. This factor will be measured through Likert items such as "The information provided by travelers guides me to visit new destinations" and "Information provided by travelers is more reliable than information shared by travel businesses." The average score reflects the extent to which respondents rely on other travelers' shared information when making travel decisions.

Marketing. The influence of tourism-related marketing activities conducted through social media (ads, promotions, brand pages, campaigns) on tourists' behavior and destination decisions. Items will include statements like "Social media has led to a significant change in tourist behavior, marketing activities, and travel information sharing" and "Social media provides information about new tourism destinations." The mean score on these items will show how strongly respondents perceive social-media marketing as affecting their travel choices.

Sex. Refers to the biological category of the respondent, identified as male or female. In this study, sex will be self-reported and treated as a nominal demographic variable.

Social media. Refers to online platforms such as Facebook, Instagram, TikTok, YouTube, and similar applications where users create, share, and interact with travel-related content. In this study, social media is the main environment through which information, images, and marketing messages that influence tourist destination preference are accessed.

Time spent on social media. Refers to the average number of hours per day that respondents use social media platforms. In this study, it will be measured by asking respondents to choose a time range (e.g., less than 1 hour, 1–2 hours, 3–4 hours, more than 4 hours) and will be analyzed as an ordinal profile variable.

Tourism satisfaction on social media. Tourists' level of satisfaction with tourism services and experiences, as reflected in and influenced by information they encounter and share on social media.Measured through items such as "I was generally satisfied with the services provided by the tourism enterprises I had previously received services from" and "The quality of the service provided by the tourism establishment increases my satisfaction." Higher **mean scores** indicate higher tourism satisfaction related to destinations discovered or reinforced through social media.

Tourist destination choice. Refers to the degree to which tourists favor or choose particular destinations after being exposed to social media content. In this study, tourist destination preference is the main dependent variable and will be measured through Likert-scale items on information shared by travelers, destination image on social media, behavioral intention on social media, effects of social media on marketing, and tourism satisfaction on social media.

Tourists. Are persons who travel to places outside their usual environment for a short period for leisure, relaxation, or other non-work purposes. In this study, tourists are non-resident visitors from Generations X, Y, and Z, aged 18 and above, who visit the selected resorts in Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen and have used social media in planning or deciding their trip.

User-generated content (UGC). Refers to posts, photos, videos, comments, and stories shared by ordinary travelers on social media. In this study, UGC is reflected in statements under "information shared by travelers" and related scales, indicating how such peer-created content influences respondents' perceptions and choices.

CHAPTER 2

RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

This chapter discusses the research design, research locale, research respondents, and research instruments that will be used in the study. It also explains the ethical standards, data-gathering procedures, and statistical treatment involved.

2.1 Research Design

The researchers will use a quantitative method, including a set of survey questionnaires, to determine the impact of social media on tourists' destination choices in the municipalities of Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen, Agusan del Norte. This research design allows the researchers to collect measurable data regarding how social media platforms influence people's decisions

when choosing a travel destination. The quantitative method was most appropriate for this study because it enabled the researchers to analyze relationships between respondents' profiles, their social media usage, and their travel-related behavior.

The survey questionnaire will be based on the study by Halit Akın & Şener (2024)and will undergo reliability and validity testing to ensure the accuracy of data collection.

2.2 Research Materials and Methods

Research Locale

The research will take place in Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen, three towns in the province of Agusan del Norte, Caraga Region (Region XIII), Mindanao, Philippines.

Buenavista is a first-class municipality founded on January 1, 1937, but was first established in 1877. It has 25 barangays and is known for its beautiful views of Butuan Bay, its rich coastal resources, and its historical significance as one of the province's first settlements. The name Buenavista, which means "good view" in Spanish, is a good fit because of its natural beauty and coastal charm.

Nasipit, a first-class municipality, is known as Agusan del Norte's industrial and port gateway. It was founded during the Spanish era and grew into a significant trading port. Now it has 19 barangays. Its location along Butuan Bay makes it a center for maritime trade, business, and industrial growth in the Caraga Region.

The town of Carmen was officially made a second-class municipality in 1949. It has eight barangays and is on the northern coast of the province. Carmen started as a small fishing village, but over time, it has grown into a modern town known for its farming, fishing, and peaceful coastal communities.

These three towns were chosen because they are close to each other, share similar coastal features, and are increasingly involved in tourism and social media. It makes them perfect places to study how social media affects where people choose to go on vacation.

2.3 Research Environment, Population, and Sample

The respondents of the study will be tourists from Generations X, Y, and Z who are 18 years old and above and are visiting the developing beach destinations of Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen, Agusan del Norte during the data-gathering period. These municipalities and establishments were selected through purposive sampling based on tourism and LGU records showing that they are registered, operating beach resorts or similar accommodations with an active social media presence. Only non-resident tourists who have used social media in planning or deciding on their trip and who are willing to participate are included, while local residents, resort staff/owners, those below 18, and those who did not use social media for their travel decisions are excluded. From the total tourist population across all identified establishments (22,617), a sample size of 376 was determined using a standard sample size formula. The researchers then applied proportionate stratified sampling to distribute this total sample among the individual resorts: each establishment was treated as a stratum, and its allotted number of respondents was computed based on its share of the total tourist population, which explains why larger resorts received more respondents and smaller ones fewer. Within each resort, qualified tourists were finally selected through accidental or intercept sampling until the target number per establishment was reached, resulting in the distribution of respondents per resort shown in Table 1.

Table 1. Population of Respondents

Resorts Location	Establishment	Population (Male)	Population (Female)	Total population	Sample (Male)	Sample (Female	Total Sample	Percentage

Buenavista	Cembrano Beach Resort	1,532	506	2,038	22	7	29	7.6
	Donabelle Cottages	2,070	720	2,790	29	10	39	10.4
	Mars Cottages	1,982	889	2,871	28	13	41	10.7
	Pamela Beach Resorts	1,484	636	1,484	21	9	30	7.9
	Adia's Beach Resort	2,047	783	2,047	29	11	40	10.6
Nasipit	Lariosa's Place	315	31	672	4	5	10	2.5
	Felias Beach Resorts	411	519	930	6	7	13	3.5
	Mantalio View Resthouse	216	158	374	3	2	5	1.4
Carmen	Painawa Beach Resort	86	128	214	1	2	3	0.8
	Bolihon Cove	1,746	1,879	3,635	25	27	51	13.5
	Kimberrey Beach Resort	244	662	662	3	6	9	2.5
	Lawis Beach Garden & Cottages	117	162	279	2	2	4	1.0
	Mahigalaon Beach Resort	972	988	1,960	14	14	28	7.3
	Payag Beach Resort	68	102	170	1	1	2	0.6
	Solar Beach Resorts	147	151	298	2	2	4	1.1
	Sunrise Beach Resort	207	243	450	3	3	6	2.4
	Talisay Aqua Sport Beach Resort	210	213	423	3	3	6	1.6
	Veranda's Beach Resort	105	120	225	1	2	3	0.8
	Vin4 Blue Water Beach Resort	1,673	2,013	3,686	24	28	32	13.8
Total		17,702	10,659	22, 617	221	156	376	100.0

Table 1. shows the distribution of respondents involved in the study. Specifically, Municipalities in Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen.

2.4 Research Data and Analysis Plan

Research Instrument

The research instrument for this study will consist of an adapted survey questionnaire anchored on the scale developed by Halit Akın and Büşra Şener (2024) on the influence of social media on destination choice. Their validated instrument is composed of 33 close-ended statements grouped into six factors: information shared by travelers (5 items), destination image on social media (5 items), behavioral intention on social media (7 items), the effects of social media on marketing (7 items), tourism satisfaction on social media (5 items), and destination preference (4 items), all originally measured using a Likert scale. In line with the present schematic diagram, the questionnaire will be divided into three parts. Part I will gather the respondents' profile in terms of age, sex, civil status, employment status, educational attainment, average monthly income, type of social network used, time spent on social media, and frequency of social media use. Part II will adapt the 29 items from the first five factors of Akın and Şener's scale to measure the social media elements: information shared by travelers, destination image on social media, behavioral intention on social media, the effects of social media on marketing, and tourism satisfaction on social media. Part III will adapt the 4 items under destination preference to measure the respondents' tourist destination choice in the context of Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen. All items in Parts II and III will be rated using a four-point Likert scale: 4 – Strongly Agree, 3 – Agree, 2 – Disagree, and 1 – Strongly Disagree. Expert validation and pilot testing will be conducted to ensure the clarity, reliability, and accuracy of the adapted items before the questionnaire is administered to tourists in Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen.

Statistical Treatment

In presenting, analyzing, and interpreting the data, the researchers will use the following statistical tools:

Frequency and Percentage – This tool will be used to answer SOP 1 by determining the profile of the respondents in terms of age, sex, civil status, employment status, educational attainment, average monthly income, type of social network used, time spent on social media, and frequency of social media use.

Weighted Mean – This tool will be used to answer SOP 2 by determining the level of the social media elements, namely: information shared by travelers, destination image on social media, behavioral intention on social media, the effects of social media on marketing, and tourism satisfaction on social media, as well as the overall level of tourist destination choice.

Correlation Analysis (Pearson r) – When the responses are grouped according to the respondents' profiles and social media elements, this tool will be used to answer SOP 3 and ascertain whether there will be a significant relationship between (a) the respondents' profiles and tourist destination choice, and (b) the social media elements and tourist destination choice.

2.5 Research Ethical Standards

A. Intellectual Property Rights

This study upheld intellectual property rights by preserving the respondent's anonymity throughout the analysis. All secondary data and existing literature were appropriately cited, respecting the intellectual property of others while safeguarding the researcher's own contribution.

B. Informed Consent

The participants in this study will be Gen X, Y, and Z travelers who utilize social media platforms to select or plan their travel destinations. Before engaging in the study, the researchers administered a brief orientation to clarify the research objective: to assess the influence of social media on the selection of tourist destinations. There will be a talk about the possible benefits and a few risks of taking part in the orientation. The people who answered the questions were told they could leave the study at any time without having to give a reason. During orientation, each respondent will be given a written consent form to ensure they understand all their rights.

C. Data Privacy and Confidentiality

The personal data collected, including respondents' demographic profiles, will be handled with strict confidentiality and only with respondents' explicit consent via an informed consent form. To protect the identities of the people who will answer the questions, all data will be anonymized. The researchers will be responsible for distributing the questionnaires to ensure that responses remain private. The code that linked identification numbers to respondents was available only to the researchers. We ensured that all collected data remained completely private, protecting respondents' privacy at all times.

D. Voluntary participation

People who will take part in the study will do so of their own free will. Participants in the study will be informed of their right to withdraw at any time without adverse consequences. This study will not involve animals; therefore, exploring alternatives to animal use is not relevant.

E. Minimization of Harm

To make the study safe and supportive, the researchers will treat the respondents with respect and professionalism. If there are any risks, the respondents will be referred to the appropriate support services, such as the clinic or the Guidance Office, to ensure their safety and

well-being. After the participants are done, the researchers will hold a debriefing session to ensure that no one is physically, mentally, or emotionally harmed during the research. The study will not employ animal subjects; consequently, the 3Rs principles of replacement, reduction, and refinement will be irrelevant.

F. Beneficence

This study will enhance the comprehension of the impact of social media on the destination choice of Gen X, Y and Z travelers. The survey results will help tourism educators, marketers, and groups by showing how social media affects people's travel choices and where they want to go. The study's results will also help people understand how their use of social media will affect their travel choices.

G. Fairness and Justice in Picking Participants

The process of choosing will be clear, fair, and in line with the study's goals. There won't be any bias or unfairness when you include people from different backgrounds.

H. The accuracy and integrity of data

You can be sure that the results are correct and reliable when you use standard methods to collect and analyze data. The researchers will first ask the school registrar for a complete list of everyone who can take part in the study. There will be no restrictions on the study, and all of the results will be thoroughly examined to ensure accuracy and impartiality.

I. Clear Reporting

The study's results will be reported accurately, without any changes or data manipulation. To protect intellectual property rights and follow ethical research practices, all sources, including academic references, will be appropriately cited and credited. The research will employ specific AI tools to assist with various aspects of the study. The study will not disclose any possible conflicts of interest.

J. Using materials that are protected by patents or copyrights

This study does not use any patented materials. Intellectual property laws say that all references and other copyrighted materials must be cited correctly. The researchers will make sure to credit all their sources, which will promote academic honesty and prevent plagiarism.

K. Things to think about for people who are subjects

The researchers will inform the people taking part in the study about the possible risks and benefits and ensure that everyone signs an informed consent form. If there are any serious risks, like emotional, physical, or mental ones, health monitoring programs and emotional support services will be available.

L. Responsible Use of AI and Related Technology

The researchers will use digital tools throughout the research process, such as finding trustworthy articles to ensure the study is accurate and reliable. AI tools like ChatGPT will be used to summarize statements and improve the study. To find supporting studies, we will use platforms like Google Scholar, Elicit, and Typeset.io. Will ensure the research is reliable and trustworthy. Grammarly will also be used to ensure the research report is clear and well-grammared. Using technology responsibly will help keep the study's integrity.

M. Ethical Approval

The research obtained ethical approval from the Institutional Review Board of Saint Michael College of Caraga, confirming its compliance with all relevant guidelines on the protection of respondents, data privacy, and intellectual property rights.

2.6 Data Gathering Procedure

Researchers sent a request letter to the school registrar to get the complete list of people who took part in the study. The CTHM dean checked the letter. Then, the statistician got this list to make sure that the population stayed the same. After confirming this, the researchers made

the research tool and tested its validity to make sure it was correct. After that, the researchers did pilot tests and sent the results to the statistician to get a reliable research tool for the study. After that, the researchers sent a letter of approval to the CTHM dean to ask for permission to do the analysis. After getting permission, the researchers did the actual data collection. They sent out the survey questionnaire to get the results. After gathering all the data, the researchers counted all the answers from the questionnaires and sent the results to the statistician to make sure they were correct and reliable. The researchers looked at, talked about, and made sense of the data they got from the statistician.

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